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The Emerging Political Actors in the Anthropocene: Cosmopolitics of the Earthbounds in Amitav Ghosh's *Gun Island*

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Abstract

The present article seeks to engender a much-needed political ecocriticism for our time. In doing so, it draws on Bruno Latour's notions of the political subject/agent in the Anthropocene. Having done that, it proposes an extrapolated version of Latour's earthbounds as the new political actors in the Anthropocene. In conformity with Latour, the present author holds that "Earthbound" does not refer to an identity. Nor does it refer to structural subjectivity. According to me, it is an onto-political redescription of humans, subjected to the limits articulated by Planetary boundaries. In its essence, earth-bound names an ontology as well as a cosmopolitics of a concerned yet debating public. As an ontology it posits that, at present or in the near future, the earth offers no exit for earthlings, who, having left the pages of Science Fiction, have now acquired a new meaning, i.e., all living beings of the earth. As a politics it refers to a journey from Modernity to

Nonmodernity—towards a new democracy of human and nonhuman agents in the earth's Critical Zone, away from a space-faring cult of a Globalized *world* which is incommensurable with the figure of our *planet,* a limited, local, polluted, war-torn, and closed envelope where life has uniquely maintained habitable condition for the last 3.5 billion years. Although Latour argued that the Anthropocene issues have only seen a public as part of the problem, the present author holds that the earthbound public is gradually becoming part of the solution. Additionally, there exists a small body of fictions which depict/anticipate such a political moment. However, as such conclusions raise further questions about the mode of earthbound politics, the article extends those questions to the fictional matrix of Amitav Ghosh's Planetary novel *Gun Island* which delineates the cosmopolitical process of the earthbounds in the Anthropocene.

Keywords: Planetary Fiction, Anthropocene Cosmopolitics, Earthbounds, Environmental Politics, Bruno Latour

Who are the Political Actors of the Anthropocene?

A new specter is haunting the planet Earth—the hybrid and shapeless specter of the Anthropocene. Except that this time, there is no one to exorcise this ghost—not only because there is nothing otherworldly about it, being produced by the sciences formerly devoted to knowing only the nonhuman Nature, but also because the entire humanity is present in the phenomenon as active agents. Although this new specter, implicating "one" humanity in its very name and subjecting everyone to the "same" disaster, was supposed to be a unifying force rallying all humans under one rubric, we painfully witness that humanity gets ever more divided as climate change keeps breeding inequality, producing people like those belonging to no nation state. So, the prevailing forms of nationalist identity politics can no longer address the transnational scope of climate change. Nor can we construe the entire humanity, contrary to what Arias-Maldonado speculates, as a political actor when only new wars seem imminent (Arias-Maldonado 2022, 160). Who will act if there is no political agent in the Anthropocene? Before one can even begin to

answer such a question, one needs to be familiar with this new climatic regime. While acknowledging various existing frameworks redirecting the question of accountability inherent in the term "The Anthropocene," my definitional position[1] reframes anew the debates around the Anthropocene politics. This position upholds a relational ontology and a planetary politics envisioning an absolutely inclusive democracy where nonhumans and naturalized humans are politically represented. This framework does not consider nonhumans as mute victims of Nature as the Gaia hypothesis pointed towards the glorious history of rudimentary lifeforms bootstrapping themselves in a hostile environment and changing the earth systems fundamentally to make it conducive for their living (Lovelock and Margulis 1974). Yet, the agency of nonhumans have so far been swept under the carpet as their work is always framed against the laws of Nature. Nonhumans keep deriving their limits and definition from a higher frame like Nature or ecology. Laws, if any, emerge from the ground. Laws are made by humans in association with their nonhumans and must be considered as situated. If the agential relations on the ground do not hold, laws fall apart. The Anthropocene is such a moment when natural laws at the level of the earth have been violated by the concerted agency of all planetary actors, humans and nonhumans. Therefore, in a relational reality, one cannot consider the earth as exclusively moved by

[1] Although there exist an array of definitions and alternative names, the present article begins with a provisional definition of the Anthropocene: It is our *present* geological age which is caused by the *collective agency* of all earthlings*, humans or not*. The name "Anthropocene" has a political implication as it points to the collective human accountability. Alternative names like Plantationocene (Haraway 2019), Chthulucene (Haraway 2019), Capitalocene (Moore 2017), Manthropocene (Raworth 2017), Anthropo-not-seen (Cadena 2022), and Anthrobscene (Parrika 2014) redirect this question of accountability in several ways. However, the present paper is a journey from accountability to accounts as embodied by its radical empirical ethnographic approach and use of an active literary work of our time embodying the politics of the public. Thus, it holds that although the Anthropocene is thoroughly political, it is so in a radically different sense. The Anthropocene is a matter of concern around which a dissenting public gathers urgently.

humans, that too, "humans as a whole." Thus, the existing scholarship in humanities has extensively debated the question of accountability in the Anthropocene while the expert scientists debated the question of dating the Anthropocene, as if the Anthropocene is just a question of a name or a date. I hold that the Anthropocene proposal is the destruction of all forms of Modern attempts to gloss over the agency of humans and nonhumans. Additionally, while my arguments do not invalidate the question of accountability, it seeks shift our focus to questions like what we are left with in a lawless planet and what we can do now for a relational but just earth. The present article seeks to find the possible answers to these questions through a theorization fed by the politics of *Gun Island*, which is a thoroughly nonmodern novel. Modernity is notorious for its tendency to arrange reality into mutually exclusive binary domains like humans/nonhumans, Nature/Society, science/politics, subject/object, Local/Global, facts/values and so on (Latour 1993; Plumwood 1993). The novel shows that these distinctions can no longer be sustained, as the Anthropocene, made of the hybrids of Nature-Society, science-politics, facts-values, and subject-object, has emerged out of an interaction between human and nonhuman agencies, localized yet infringing political boundaries.

Under Modernity, the nonhuman earth has been an "object" of human knowledge; an inert, distant, and ahistorical background against which active human subjects of history could show their autonomy. However, in the Anthropocene, planet earth, the former immovable ground of natural laws, has come to be moved by the action of human subjects and can no longer be treated as a motionless stage for performing human characters. Consequently, the nonhuman earth in the Anthropocene has become a "subject" because subjectivity is "not to act autonomously in front of an objective background, but to *share agency with other subjects that have also lost their autonomy*" (Latour 2014, 5). In the new climate regime, when humans and the nonhuman earth agentically subject each other, both emerge as subjects.[2] Additionally, as there are traces of human action everywhere, there is no distance anymore between human subjects and the nonhuman earth (Latour 2014, 5-6).

[2] In fact, subjectivity is the necessary condition of agency.

Thus, the latter ceases to be "objective"[3] and demonstrates a subjective form of action. Democratic politics in the Anthropocene, therefore, must welcome the nonhumans into its folds. In short, in the Anthropocene, once Nature is dissolved for good, both humans and nonhumans have become subjects to each other's agency. Both of them must now share the same political ground as witnessed in *Gun Island*. The novel invokes a parliament of human and nonhuman beings (Ghosh 2019, 281).

In traditional sociology, subjectivity and agency are invariably associated with the notion of socio-political structures. However, once the nonhumans are established as agents and subjects, the idea of society as an exclusive domain of human associations falls apart. As established sociology deals with humans alone, it cannot account for myriads of living and nonliving nonhumans that fundamentally construct society by associating with humans. As the earth is relegated deep into the Anthropocene, sociology, originally the study of (as)sociation, must consider the agency and subjectivity of nonhumans, a feat accomplished by Ghosh in *Gun Island.* Now more than ever, it is imperative for sociology to stop giving social *explanations* of society and start offering *descriptions* of associations among heterogeneous actors. The structural explanations of traditional sociology become redundant if one is firmly established in a radical empirical position, as structural effect, if any, is always instantiated in the ground where the ethnographer must land to follow and describe the action of human and nonhuman agents as they modify and subjectify each other. Once one situates oneself in the ground, agency must no longer be considered as the ability to modify only "socio-political" structures. Instead, one begins to appreciate the competence of all agents, the infinite possibilities of alliance among them, and their ability to modify each other. This is an empowering redescription of the same subjects who are interpreted as slaves of structures. Irrespective of the notion of structure, agency[4] must now be defined, as in semiotics, as the ability to make "some difference to a state of affairs, transforming some As into Bs through trials with Cs" (Latour 2005, 52-53). The trials that

[3] As objectivity is predicated on a *distance* between subject and object.

[4] Anthony Giddens defines agency as the "capability of individuals [humans] to make a difference to a pre-existing state of affairs or course of events" (Giddens 1984, p. 14).

the human and nonhuman actors withstand as they modify each other, make them competent to reproduce themselves. Such hybrid interactions among competent heterogeneous subjects, as the earth systems are transformed under the pressure of eight billion humans, call for a "sociology of association" that brings all actors down to the ground, a territory to be traced and outlined by immense and hybrid networks of action, a ground that *Gun Island* traces.

The said ground in the novel is not just the cartographic surface of the earth but the enclosing pellicle of the planet, multiple "Critical Zones" spanning from the canopy to the mother rock where various animate and inanimate associations have maintained life for the last 3.5 billion years (Arènes, Latour, and Gaillardet 2018, 2).[5] This is a place marked by extreme plurality. Here, every few miles associations change. Here, nonhuman agency and social action cannot be told apart. Let me call this ground "Planetary." Planetary is not Global, a Modern enterprise and a cartographic notion having nothing to do with the planet. While the Global was supposed to acknowledge multiplicity and variety, in the world of *Gun Island*, it has ironically come to mean "a single vision, entirely provincial, proposed by a few individuals, representing a very small number of interests, limited to a few measuring instruments, to a few standards and protocols, [. . .] imposed on everyone and spread everywhere" (Latour 2018, Sec. 4). For me, nobody can belong to the Globe of this Global which is exclusively meant for a handful of citizens-of-the-world. Likewise, Planetary is not local, another Modern initiative having little to do with a premodern space for belonging. In the scheme of the novel, it is made in reaction to the Global and defined by boundaries inscribed by nationalist identity politics. While this version of the local closes itself off, Planetary opens itself up. This local is undemocratic not only for nonhumans but also for humans as it overlooks the prevailing uproar made by the millions of contradictory voices. The novel acknowledges that belonging to a territory requires localized presence albeit with connections beyond boundaries. Having said that, this thoroughly Modern Local

[5] According to Lovelock and Margulis (1974), all lifeforms have a role to play in determining their environment along the deep history of the earth. This conclusion is reclaimed by Lenton and Latour (2018).

in the novel does not offer a livable space either, as exemplified by the younger generation abandoning the climate altered Sundarbans for European nations. Consequently, in the novel, the Local and the Global have both become unattractive as the former puts up walls and the latter is only for a select few. However, the third position—Planetary—has rapidly become achievable, as the characters fumble for a localized territory, offering a place to firmly plant their feet while simultaneously having possible connections to many spaces and many times.

With this notion of the ground one can now enquire into the form of politics that can account for and compose the variety of human and nonhuman associations in the novel's world. This form of politics is neither left nor right, neither reactionary nor progressive, neither forward-marching towards the frontier of Globalization nor backward-harking to a premodern past. While the Critical Zone scientists are increasingly situating themselves on the ground to describe and study the imbrication of nonhuman agency and human social action, nonhumans remain ill-defined and under-represented in democratic politics. As a corrective measure, the Anthropocene politics of planetary fictions must welcome emerging human and nonhuman subjects and institute them as social and political: dispossessed human subjects of the new planet, endangered species, microbes, CO_2, technological actors, text, and so on. *Gun Island* has mediated the agency of these heterogeneous actors who are clamoring for their competence to be recognized in the new epoch. The urgency of the situation marked by a large-scale Planetary migration of nationless humans and nonhumans demands that the Anthropocene cosmopolitics of planetary fictions must now invoke the dissenting public on the ground.

The term "cosmopolitics" does not have the connotations of the term "cosmopolitanism" which refers to the sentiments of a handful of Global citizens with a great amount of freedom. By contrast, cosmopolitics means a more inclusive Planetary Politics, "an ambitious reframing of politics that reaches beyond settled categories, borders and territories," while being situated on the ground. (Braidotti and Hlavajova 2019, 93). In keeping with the emerging realities (e.g., novel hybrids), Anthropocene cosmopolitics, too, must transgress "categories, borders, and territories." It entails the progressive composition

of a common world of humans and nonhumans in the absence of a higher authority as exemplified in *Gun Island* (281). This political composition involves a debating public[6] and an issue. "No issue, no politics," Latour declares, as politics in all senses of the term must deal with issues (Latour 2007, 4). An issue gathers a dissenting public urgently around itself *because* it divides them (Latour 2014, 17). In the absence of a unanimous Global community, a public having different voices on an issue assembles as they are drawn towards the matters of concern. An issue related to climate change, thus, immediately collects a concerned yet disagreeing public while it gradually travels towards latter stages. The government machinery may come to represent the public's problem. As seen in *Gun Island* (273), the same issue may reach the Habermasian moment when it attracts enlightened and well-behaved problem solvers, a discussion-oriented public capable of calculation and compromise (Habermas [1962] 1989, 52-56). Thus, the same issue can leave the stage of "public as a problem" and enter the stage of "public as a solution."

Back to our original question, one must now look for the political agents in the Anthropocene. As already said, one cannot possibly have an overarching humanity reaching a consensus regarding the course of action in the Anthropocene. Nor can one see any democratic solutions to climate change in the identity politics of the nation states. Moreover, once structural subjectivity is shown to be conceptually redundant in the Anthropocene, one cannot look for different subject positions or intersections of power structures in order to attribute agency to a people driving change. In the Anthropocene, all we have is a dissenting public around climate change issues. The new era of the Anthropocene, however, has also summoned a post-natural collective of people who are part of the "public as a solution," who are overthrowing the rules of normative and religious Nature. They have a hybrid notion of society as associations; they acknowledge the agency and subjectivity of nonhumans, and yearn to belong to a ground, a territory, beyond the Local and the Global that Modernity has to offer. The cosmopolitics of these people is

[6] This debating public gathers urgently around any Planetary issue because they have different interests regarding the issue.

illustrated in the contemporary Planetary movements like "Save-Soil,"[7] "Rally for Rivers,"[8] and "Cauvery Calling"[9] which have already left an impact on public policies of several countries. These movements are by necessity cosmopolitical and earth-bound as for the activists, soil and rivers are the new political agents and subjects crossing territories. Such cosmopolitics is again seen in the movements centering the Amazon, propelled by Pachamama Alliance, an educational organization in the USA ("The Pachamama Alliance | Transformative Workshops and Amazon Advocacy" 2022). The earthbound politics is also embedded in the chapter "Rights of Nature" in the Ecuadorian Constitution where the life-supporting nonhumans are granted legal rights (2008, Ch. 7). The same cosmopolitical attitude is cultivated shortly in New Zealand, Uganda, and the Indian state of Uttarakhand where the nonhuman is offered the status of a legal person. Moreover, the cosmopolitics of this transnational collective can be felt in what Brian Tokar (2014) calls "climate justice movements," or what Rosewarne, Goodman, and Pearse (2015) designate as "climate action upsurge," or what Sidney Tarrow (2005) defines as "transnational activism."

Earthbound[10] is the name that Latour confers upon this collective. The emerging form of Planetary cosmopolitics of earthbounds is incommensurable with the identity politics of nation states. The political ground for this public is no longer the *Lebensraum* but the *Umwelt*. These people drive change through the narrativity of their accounts of

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[7] This is the largest people's movement, gathering over 4 billion citizens of the planet earth, helping the governments to take up new policies for rejuvenating soil-health.

[8] Launched in 2017, the movement is meant for revitalizing the rapidly depleting Indian rivers. It has a support of 162 million people, and it has propelled the government to formulate a USD 2.5 billion policy.

[9] The largest farmer-driven ecological movement, it seeks to restore the health of Cauvery River by supporting 5.2 million farmers to plant 2.42 billion trees through tree-based agriculture.

[10] See Latour's discussion on earthbounds in "Agency at the Time of the Anthropocene" (17), *Down to Earth* (Sec. 18), and *Facing Gaia: Eight Lectures on the New Climate Regime* (248-54).

human and nonhuman agencies. Their plural collective is built out of an alliance among various professions—novelists, writers, moralists, activists, academicians, artists, poets, journalists, lawyers, scientists, engineers, politicians, and so on—who tell their different stories around the issues of climate change and listen to the narratives that the nonhumans outline with their agency. To arrive at the cosmopolitics of this people, one needs to revise the concept of Human in humanist traditions. An ontological definition of humans, literally incarcerated by the thin layer near the surface of the earth, looking for inhabitable spaces on this planet, approximates the agency and politics of these people. Existentially, the earth is the source and destination for all humans. But, historically and politically, only the collective of these post-natural people is oriented towards the third position, the Planetary ground. By contrast, the pipedream of Modern humans does not stop at the Global Globe[11] of the future; they look towards infinite space away from the earth, towards other planets and stars in search of resources. Thus, Modern humans and this deliberating collective occupy opposite ends of the same axis that embodies two movements in opposite direction—"towards the earth" and "away from the earth." This new axis has come to replace the old axis of Local-Global along which Modern humans used to move frantically back and forth. The inbound movement along the new axis represents an onto-political journey towards the Planetary, to which the earthbounds keep inching forward. One becomes conscious of the double-meaning of the "earthbound — 'bound' as if bound by a spell, as well as 'bound' in the sense of heading somewhere, thereby designating the joint attempt to reach the Earth while being unable to escape from it" (Latour 2013, 117). Thus, Latourian "earthbound" names an ontology as well as the politics of a public as seen in *Gun Island*. While Modern humans look for the universe, an infinite space extended in every direction—*res extensa*—where the earth is suspended as just another planet among many other planets, earthbounds of the novel engage in space-making on the earth which is a planet like no other. The earthbound characters of the novel have accepted the earth, offering no exit, as the only planet they have. Rather than exploring the infinite universe,

[11] Global is a vision of the future of the earth as the Globe which is translated both temporally and spatially, by means of the cartographic space and an imaginary future dependent on the juggernaut of Globalization, the pinnacle of Modernity.

they propose an infinite engagement with the limited and local planet they are left with. They are firmly established in the Planetary. As the apparition of the Anthropocene looms large, Modern humans, too, must come to terms with the reality that they do not have four planets to materialize the dreams of Globalization and that at present or in near future, other planets away from the earth do not hold any promise for the earthlings to democratically inhabit. They must realize that they, too, are literally confined by the earth as earthbounds, neither a group nor a subject position, but an existentially and politically entangling condition all humans are forever subjected to.

The original question—who are the political actors of the Anthropocene? —now has yielded an answer but such a solution brings further questions in its wake. Certainly, earthbounds will act by resisting Modern humans and swarming around Planetary issues. But who will have the final say in the great democratic debate that ensues from a gathering public, earthbounds as well as Modern humans? Are they scientists whose facts freeze all values, or settle all debates? It cannot be so anymore although it has been the practice for the last few centuries. Facts are extremely limited rendition of more fundamental values that involve more interactive agencies and more accounts. It is the value that engenders facts. Therefore, no single profession can dominate the discussion around an issue as the Anthropocene is a shapeless phantasmal phenomenon progressively and tentatively delineated by the agency of people from all professions. It hardly matters if an issue was formerly known as natural or social. People belonging to all professions must keep a climate change issue alive. More questions follow. How will the earthbounds resist Modern humans? Or more importantly, how can they advance their common cosmopolitics? Again, to rephrase, how will they compose a chaotic and closed cosmos of humans and nonhumans in the absence of a higher authority?

Cosmopolitics in *Gun Island*: Earthbounds as Part of the Solution

These questions seem to yield several answers if they are extended to the world of Anthropocene Fictions (Trexler 2015). Some of the fictions of this category, dubbed as

Planetary Fictions by the present author,[12] represent the action, subjectivity, and cosmopolitics of the earthbounds. Regarding fiction, the term "Planetary" is often used to refer to a spatial scale pertaining to the cartographic globe (Crownshaw 2017, 895). It is also used to refer to temporally far-future romances, set on other planets and displaced from the earth's common history, epitomized in the representative fictional works of Aldiss ([1982] 1985), Bradley (1972), De Camp (1971), Foster ([1975] 1979), Silverberg ([1980] 2020), and Vance ([1950] 2008). The present author, nonetheless, uses the term "Planetary Fiction" to emphasize the earth-centric politics of these fictions. Whereas all Anthropocene Fictions are unified under the theme of climate change, most of them paint an apocalyptic and undemocratic *future* when no resource is left to use for most of the earthlings who are still alive, survival of the fittest has become the norm of day-to-day living, or as if the planet earth was not a sufficient backdrop for the apocalypse, the space colonies proliferate to serve as the setting of the technological sublime, dystopia, or on some occasions, the much-awaited promised land of Utopia, the no-place! However, some Anthropocene Fictions choose to recognize the planet earth as it is *at present*—a fragile and unique entity, the only planet humans have; in short, they follow Planetarity as their politics. Unlike the temporal scheme of the Modern political spectrum, longing either for the security of the past or the freedom of the future, the spatial vector of the politics of Planetary Fictions consists in looking down to Earth—the ground. Dissenting earthbounds in these stories gather around issues that the planet earth raises as various hybrids of facts and values. These stories invent unlikely alliance or sabotage, represent distributed action[13] to create a

[12] The category does not denote a genre but the politics of a body of fiction (Author, 2023).

[13] Agency is not owned by individual actors. Agency is nothing but the mutual translation process that happens in the network of human and nonhuman actors. Thus, "whose agency?" is a wrong question. The location of agency is always the "network." This distributed notion of agency in the Anthropocene must be differentiated from the definition of agency in traditional social sciences which posits, first, that human subjects are the only possible agents, second, that agency involves the transformation of "social structures" by

just planet earth, situate[14] the action in the network, while simultaneously redistributing agency to many spaces and many times. These fictions create agential networks to identify, represent, and address losses that have already been suffered, the apocalypse that is presently unravelling, and the deep-seated despair of everyday life of the human and nonhuman characters in the climate-altered earth, successfully bringing science and technology down to the great democratic debate. The technological sublime is of no use for Planetary Fictions as, in most of these fictions, the earth is shaped and maintained by a plethora of protagonists who *work* towards a better time for coexisting with the planet.

Amitav Ghosh's novel *Gun Island* is one such Planetary Fiction representing a network-like, overlapping, earthly entanglement of myriads of human and nonhuman subjects across time and space. In its depiction of the Anthropocene issues, the novel never forgets its definition of democracy. It portrays an array of nonhuman actors as they play the roles of saboteurs or allies for humans, as their agency and human agency, recorded in the curves and crevices of an agitated earth, cannot be told apart, and as they share a common destiny with humans in their climate exodus across continents. Moreover, the earthbound subjects in the novel resist Modern humans and compose a common cosmos shared by all earthlings. The novel depicts this cosmopolitical process by making a deliberating public from various professions gather around issues like human and nonhuman migration, a composite phenomenon. Furthermore, as already noted, the earthbound characters of the

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the agent. Structural effects on the ground also count as action but they must be completely traceable and should be analyzed on the flat territory of the network in association with other agents.

[14] All action must be situated in the Anthropocene. Modern domains of Nature, Society, and Text traditionally serving as explanatory domains for all agencies must be discarded now as their normative powers are merely due to the situated work behind their formation and maintenance. In the Anthropocene, we must resort to the task of describing agencies across the domains rather than availing ready-made explanations, as natural, social, or discursive explanations always hijack agency from the actors and undermine the freedom of agential association they always instantiate.

novel are disillusioned with both the Globe of the Global and the identity politics of the Local, and are attracted towards the Planetary, the third position, that is localized yet intensely connected to multiple spaces and times. In doing so, the novel shows the transnational scope of Planetary politics of the earthbounds, the new political actors of the Anthropocene.

Here is an *amodern* novel that wages a war against Modern humans as it demolishes the categorical approaches to the agentically entangling condition of our planet. For example, it explodes the well-explained, "purified" world of Deen, the first-person narrator, as he encounters the hybrid reality of a climate-altered earth. To Deen's consternation, hybrid actors of the Anthropocene keep proposing themselves to him to gain his recognition so that they can be translated into collective beings of the new democratic cosmos. Nationless humans, erratic storms, mythical actors like Manasa Devi and the Gun Merchant, various migrating and endangered species of birds, beasts, and marine mammals make well-articulated "propositions" to the earthbound collective to which Deen, too, must belong by the end of the novel.[15] He must continuously face two crucial political questions, "how many are we?" and "can we live together?" Over the course of the novel, he is gradually being prepared to answer these questions. His conversation with several earthbounds including Nilima, Piya, Horen, Rafi, and Cinta destabilizes his Modern attitude to the world. In the first part of the novel, titled "The Gun Merchant," his natural explanations miserably fail to make sense of the chaotic agencies of the earthlings of the Tide Country while the readers catch him heaving a sigh of relief when he boards the plane bound for Brooklyn, "an impregnably metallic, mechanical, man-made womb," offering safety and protection against the "the world of mud and its slithering, creeping inhabitants" (Ghosh 2019,101-102). Deen's rational worldview becomes walls of self-imprisonment from which he must be set free. Only gradually does it dawn on him that recognizing the hybrid and entangled world of humans and nonhumans is a kind of awakening or a

[15] See Latour's elaboration of the term "propositions" in *Politics of Nature: How to Bring the Sciences into Democracy* (83) and *Pandora's Hope: Essays on the Reality of Science Studies* (303).

risveglio as Cinta puts it. He realizes that humans and nonhumans are equally articulated beings as articulation is not just a property of human speech but an ontological property of all earthlings, humans or not. The novel delineates that Deen's freedom lies in his multiplicity of hybrid attachments. Deen gradually starts accessing this freedom as he turns into an earthbound once he starts caring for others around him, and as he "fell silent, overtaken by an overwhelming feeling of gratitude" to his nonhuman allies (Ghosh 2019, 271).

Although Deen's metamorphosis from a Modern human to an earthbound subject can be studied at some length, for the limited purpose of looking into the specificities of the Anthropocene cosmopolitics, the present article will substantiate how the deliberative earthbound public of the novel contribute to the solution by composing a plural collective of heterogeneous earthlings. As already said, earthbounds compose the earth by assembling around Planetary issues. A similar assembly takes place in the novel's climactic scene, realized in the narrative present, when everyone prepares for the arrival of the blue fishing boat carrying the nationless migrants looking for a place to "land," to place their feet on, to belong. The issue of the scene is the Blue Boat which collects everyone, including, as the present author holds, the enormous column of nonhuman beings. This extrapolation is supported by a speculative gesture in the story because the Ethiopian woman representing the migrants of the Blue Boat seems to communicate with the spiraling silo of the nonhuman birds and marine mammals. Ghosh here uses his authorial license to bring the nonhumans around the Blue Boat, the matter of concern. In doing so, he acknowledges the necessity to *represent* the nonhumans in the new parliament of the Anthropocene. As the Ethiopian woman performs the "miracle" in her role of a *portavoce*, a voice carrier between the worlds of nonhumans and humans, this scene acquires a symbolic dimension, representing, in terms of images, the metamorphic zone of the planet earth, the meeting ground of the former subjects and the former objects. In fact, this sublime sight of the angelomorphic woman in her alliance with the migrants—humans, birds, and marine mammals—is interpreted as a *miracle* by many including the Italian admiral who rescues the refugees shortly afterwards. Her "robed figure," as the woman stands "erect between

the bows," and as she raises her arms to become a part of the living storm, writes a performative manifesto for her borderless human and nonhuman comrades—demanding the *Umwelt* in the Anthropocene (Ghosh 2019, 281).

The Blue Boat exposes the identity politics of civilized European countries at a time when the enthusiastic marching-forward of people towards the Global Globe has already become a quixotic venture once everyone has grasped that the cartographic Globe is meant only for a select few. Nation states have realized that Globalization is a failed project faced with the new figure of the earth in the throes of climate change—a degenerate system with finite resources. Historically, this recent disillusionment with the Global is followed by an enchantment of the made-over Local, having nothing to do with a premodern space for belonging but is instantiated by visible and invisible walls of self-preservation. This contemporary movement towards the Local, rather than enabling the nation states to open up, closes them off against the refugees including even those who are afflicted by climate change. In the narrative present of the story, if the Globe can no longer offer a livable place for most of the characters, the insularity of the nation states, too, fails to offer a space for belonging to the nameless human migrants. These refugees neither conform to the normative Globe nor to the restricting living condition of the Local. Consequently, they have become the dispossessed of the Planetary ground. Their indignation is where resources of politics can be found, as they wait at the door of the collective, demanding a place within it. They constitute the crisis of the earth at present. The political vision of the Global cannot accommodate them. Nor can nationalist politics accept them into its fold. However, only a cosmopolitics of the earthbounds can embrace these expendable, nameless, disinherited of the earth, as cosmopolitics, in one of its senses, involves letting in new actors who have shown their competence, giving their due place inside the collective, and not questioning their existence further.

Eventually, Gisa's words to Deen confirm that the biggest contemporary political issue in Europe is the migration of people from places like the Middle East, Africa, Pakistan, Iraq, Afghanistan, and Bangladesh. The reader also learns that the new right-wing nationalist government in Italy came to power as they promised a crackdown on migration.

The fact that election results are decided over the issue of migration reflects first, that climate change has become political, and second, that the country, like other nations, has come to define itself by its ethnic boundaries. No country in the Mediterranean is ready to admit the "forlorn little fishing boat" carrying the refugees (Ghosh 2019, 276). Ironically, this tiny boat with a flaking coat of blue paint becomes so enormous in its impact on international politics that in order to stop it, the Italian government deploys no less than four watchful warships "as though they were waiting to ambush an enemy armada" (Ghosh 2019, 275). Other Mediterranean countries, too, sent an array of coastguard vessels to stop the refugees from going ashore anywhere at all. Thus, quite ironically, the issue of climate migration does attract the attention of the government which, nevertheless, fails to address it in the name of the greater good. That the arrival of the migrants has become a strong issue can also be deciphered from the questions the Italian public raises regarding migration: "Why are the migrants coming, in such dangerous circumstances? What are they fleeing? What are their hopes?" (Ghosh 2019, 146). Although there are many possible answers to such questions, the novel's migrant population looking for a new dwelling is invariably plagued by climate disasters at home. The readers learn that it was due to climate change and associated losses related to life and livelihood that the characters like Rafi, Tipu, and others have left the Sundarbans delta spread out across the international border between India and Bangladesh—the hostile homeland where "geo" no longer serves as a background for "politics" but is the primary political actor.

The issue of climate refugees also convokes the "motley flotilla of vessels," hired by activist groups waiting for the appearance of the Blue Boat, showing flags and banners with slogans related to migration, including climate migration (Ghosh 2019, 272). Most of them show the sentiments of xenophobia: "Return to Sender," "No room here; go home," "We are Indigenous, the only Owners of this Continent," "Climate migration=invasion," "Enough is ENOUGH," and "Send them back with birth control" (Ghosh 2019, 272). These slogans, spelt out in various terms, are oblivious to the Planetary implications of European colonization—the practice of plantation marked by customary dispersion and relocation of people and the old-world nonhumans. It was a time when people at large entered into a new

relation with the territory. What is more, these slogans show the ongoing ubiquitous tendency of putting up walls between "our home" and "their home," "indigenous" and "settlers," "civilized" and "uncouth"—in short, between *us* and *them*—between homogeneous groups which do not exist except as reductive ideas peddled by intolerant group leaders.[16] Against those multifaceted parochial slogans, there are mantras, too, supporting the migrants in the name of God, Law, and Peace: "Immigrants are all God's children," "No human is illegal," and "Refugees are not your enemies" (Ghosh 2019, 272). These slogans, in turn, attempt to bring the refugees on equal footing with the legal European citizens in terms of human rights. Therefore, this gathering portrays an urgent assembly of a dissenting public around an issue that attracts them to itself precisely because it divides them. Thus, the reason for the gathering public on the Mediterranean lies not in their sameness but in their different interests and opinions regarding the arrival of the Blue Boat. The Blue Boat divides them only to bind and congregate them around itself. The problem has its public.

A small number of this motely public does fit the description of earthbounds, those who acknowledge that the earth is their only source and destination. Immigrant business owners like Lubna and Palash, their fellow activists, a journalist like Gisa, her crew, a fisherman-turned-daily-wage-earner like Rafi, a historian and anthropologist like Cinta, a field biologist like Piya, and a rare-book dealer like Deen onboard the Lucania join hands while facing the attacks from the jingoists on the Mediterranean. Although the right-wing activists coming from far-off places—Germany, Hungary, Russia, Singapore, and Australia—easily outnumber the earthbounds, the former is a normative, undemocratic politics having no connection with the ground. In order to contend with these Modern, hyper-nationalist humans who might block or ram the Lucania, the earthbounds "meet" on the rear-deck of the Lucania to discuss their course of action. The meeting is a practice in deliberative, solution-oriented, earthbound cosmopolitics as Deen notes, unlike meetings of the political parties, it was not guided by a leader behind the microphone "loudly

[16] See Latour's discussion on "group" and "group formation" in *Reassembling the Social: An Introduction to Actor-Network-Theory* (27-37).

haranguing their audiences" (Ghosh 2019, 273). Instead, the meeting is convened among the equals joining with their unique accounts. The decisions are reached by everyone's voice and vote. For example, the proposal of violent retaliation is dropped by the majority and after much calculation they declare "that in case another vessel approached us in a threatening manner we would join hands and face the other ship resolutely, but without resorting to violence of any kind" (Ghosh 2019, 273). Here is a conscious public settling their debates after due considerations to all voices around the issue. As a quick repartee to the hyper-national slogans from the approaching boat, the earthbounds on the Lucania hold their ground and shout back: "*NO to xenophobia! NO to hate!*" (Ghosh 2019, 274). It is true that while resisting the Moderns successfully, the earthbound public on the Lucania were made to play the role of spectators in connection with the Blue Boat. Yet, they do not merely perform a choric function of reporting the events unfolding around the slow arrival of the boat, but moreover, they bustle with activities like spotting marine mammals and the storm of birds, reporting, and sharing incoming stories from around the world. Additionally, at times, as Rafi and Cinta suspect, the events around the Lucania seem to repeat the incidents in the seventeenth-century myth of the Gun Merchant facing climate disasters. Thus, in the drama that unfolds, earthbounds onboard the Lucania are brought in connection with an extraordinarily long and entangled network involving nonhumans, humans, narratives, and deep history of the planet earth.

The figure of the earth in the novel is not that of a premodern earth, sublunar, decaying, and essentially immoral, with its people aspiring to escape it through prayer. Nor is it the earth under Modernity which portrays it as a planet among many other planets in an infinite universe. Rather, the figure of our planet in the novel is corrupt, war-torn, polluted, degenerate, and marked by erratic climate disasters. Once again, it is a sublunar, closed planet similar to the figure of the premodern earth but, this time, with no hope for religious transcendence. The figure of the planet earth that the novel portrays is closed and chaotic. It must be composed from scratch in the absence of a higher authority. The earthbounds of the novel take up exactly this task. While the climactic scene shows them contending with the Modern humans over the issue of the Anthropocene migration, most of their political

agency in the novel consists in composing the hybrid earth. They begin to compose the subjective earth by acknowledging that humans are an inextricable part of it as they have nowhere else to go, and that no amount of knowledge about the earth can get them a God's-eye-view. They recognize that Planetary agencies are not owned by actors but are distributed in the network of associating agents. Rather than explaining they describe as a means to reliably attend to the specificities on the ground. They overcome the distinction between Nature and Society and revise the definition of Society. The notion of society they propose involves associations among diverse actors, human or not. An ethnographer like Nilima, or Cinta, or a Critical Zone scientist like Piya tells the readers about how human and nonhuman lives are intricately interwoven across the territories, how fragile those connecting threads are, and how it needs our great care and love for them to evolve the way they find their fullest expression. Nilima keeps records of the storms and associated losses in order to address them. Cinta narrates the Gun Merchant's myth in connection with the seventeenth-century climate change and geopolitics. They, in fact, offer description of the world in terms of agencies irrespective of their "sources"— domains of Nature, Society, or Discourse. Their role in the novel's action consists in showing that the worlds of humans, nonhumans, and texts are equally important in weaving the texture of materiality. Notably, it is at Nilima's behest that Deen embarks on the journey to decode the Gun Merchant's mythical legend. Deen's recomposition of the chaotic associations of the legend is predicated on the unlearning of his categorical approach advocated by his "scientific world view." Consequently, the reconstructed myth swarms with unlikely associations between humans and nonhumans, science and politics, Society and Nature, facts and values, subjects and objects, people's memory and surviving texts, miracles and materiality, climate change and migration. No single view dominates the rebirth of this seventeenth-century myth. The myth, thus composed, invokes the deep history and inner workings of the earth systems as it harps on the present-day climate disasters involving migrating humans and nonhumans across the continents. Like this myth, the earth in the novel, too, is composed without an arbiter (like a scientist) to lay down beforehand the boundaries between human and nonhuman agencies, between the domains of Society and Nature, or between the scientific and political practices. Although scientific voices fundamentally contribute to the novel's

cacophony, they do not dominate the discussion. Whenever anomalies happen on the ground, for example, when something unusual happens in the cetacean world, Piya as an earthbound scientist, resorts to her ignorance: "There's a lot that we still don't know about cetaceans and their behaviour" (Ghosh 2019, 275). Earthbound scientists like Piya and Lisa "form a people. They have enemies. They belong to the territory outlined by their instruments. [. . .] The earthbound scientists no longer try to be the third party with an overview in all discussions. They are just one party; sometimes they win, sometimes they lose. They are of this world. For them, there is no shame in having allies (Latour 2017, 252)." Thus, Piya and Lisa are on equal footing with the earthbounds of other professions. Like people in other walks of life, they can access reality only as much as their allies allow them to have. However, their situated knowledge about the interaction between human and nonhuman agencies serves to significantly compose the chaotic earth in the novel. They include a host of nonhumans into the collective: migrating dolphins, whales, birds, crabs, bark beetles and so on. However, their scientific view does not settle all controversies and is considered only as important as other democratic utterances, one among many in the scope of the novel.

Some of Piya's opinions are carefully considered but are played against those of Deen, Cinta, and others. Thus, the novel suggests a new democracy where scientists are parties among many other parties. This same view is maintained for other professions and people. As Piya's description of the nonhuman world, on the one hand, includes social actions like those of fishermen, migrant humans, nylon netting, motorboats, steamers, and the refinery, on the other hand, people of other professions, too, contribute to the description of the nonhuman agencies and participate in the deliberative process regarding the institution of the nonhuman within the collective. Nilima, Deen, Lubna, Gisa, and Cinta must welcome a host of new human and nonhuman actors within the collective after due consultations with each other. Some of these actors are living, some nonliving; but all of them play a vital role in the creation and maintenance of the Critical Zone responsible for life on Earth. Although some of these actors, Manasa Devi and the Gun Merchant for example, are mythical entities having an existence and meaning in the world of human

narrativity, their agency translates the Critical Zone with significant lessons in politics for the Anthropocene. Although, there exist significant differences of views among earthbounds regarding the agency of mythical nonhumans, these differences are overcome by enlightened compromises. While Cinta passionately believes in miracles and Deen comes to flirt with the idea of the supernatural, Piya does not at all believe in any such agencies. However, these disagreements are fertile grounds for the cosmopolitics of the new democratic earth because out of these value-laden interactions of voices, emerge solutions.

The novel, thus, fleshes out the shape of the Anthropocene cosmopolitics of a heterogeneous earthbound public who contribute to the solution by gathering around issues and acknowledging and including emerging hybrid actors into their collective. In keeping with the politics of Planetary Fictions, the novel is aware of the past and the present of the agitated earth and all its earthlings. It is a proposal to redescribe and recompose the earth in the Anthropocene. Although it draws heavily on scientific findings, it is not one of those science fictions promoting a normative Science looking towards space away from the earth. The agential network in the novel gives rise to more than one earthbound protagonist who act as an enlightened public to address climate change issues. Who realize that this new age is not one of the lone ranger but of million actors. Yet, sadly, the novel also suggests that the earth can no longer be reclaimed from the spectral influence of the Anthropocene. The Gun Merchant's seventeenth century "contract" with Manasa Devi, as one between humans and nonhumans, seems to be no longer valid in the narrative present, when the earth systems have evidently turned against both human and nonhuman lives. The ghost of the Anthropocene is here to stay practically forever. However, the character of Manasa Devi, like the Ethiopian woman in the narrative present, initiates Deen to a horizontal relationship with the nonhuman. Such a cosmopolitical practice can render the earth into a cosmos, a well-composed arrangement. An earthbound redescription of the earth in terms of agencies can progressively compose this cosmos populated with chaotic and unlikely entanglements in the Planetary ground, a locale where all human and nonhuman actors are. It is on/in this ground where the dispossessed lives continually look for a dwelling. It is this ground from

which Anthropocene cosmopolitics must glean its resources. It is this ground with which the earthbounds, the new political actors of the new epoch, must engage infinitely for an eternity. The possessed constitution of the earth is in dire need of the antidote of earthbound cosmopolitics which may not offer an across-the-board cure but may responsibly and progressively address the maladies one at a time.

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